A crayfish contest leads to a science puzzle

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Biologist Caitlin Bloomer found a huge crayfish in the mud in Kentucky. Its kind is called the Crawzilla crawdad. She was sure it was the biggest crayfish ever.

But a coworker said, "No way, I've caught bigger." So Bloomer started a search across the country. She asked **museums** and scientists to check their collections for giant crayfish. The team used special tools called **calipers** to measure them carefully. They found 20 extra-large crayfish from 18 kinds.

Bloomer's Crawzilla made the top 20. The winner was a Tennessee bottlebrush crayfish kept at West Liberty University in West Virginia. Its body was 86.6 **millimeters** long, about 3.4 inches, not counting its tail and claws.

The scientists also found a puzzle. The biggest crayfish of many kinds stopped growing at about 80 **millimeters**. Their hard outer shells or their **muscles** might keep them from growing bigger.

Word Treasure

biologist -- A biologist is a scientist who studies living things.

museums -- Museums are places that collect and show important objects, including animals kept for study.

calipers -- Calipers are tools that measure the size of something very carefully.

millimeters -- Millimeters are very small units used to measure length.

muscles -- Muscles are body parts that help animals move.

Background you need

Crayfish, also called crawdads, are small freshwater animals related to lobsters.

A crayfish has a hard outer shell, and it must shed that shell to grow bigger.

Museums keep animals for many years so scientists can measure and compare them later.

Break it down

WHO: Biologist Caitlin Bloomer and scientists at museums across the country
WHAT: A search for the biggest crayfish found 20 giants and a size limit
WHERE: Kentucky, museum collections, and West Liberty University in West Virginia
WHY: A coworker said he had caught a bigger crayfish, which started a friendly contest

Why it matters

Even a friendly contest can lead to real science, showing that being curious about animals you find outside can teach us something new.

Test what you remember

1. Where did Caitlin Bloomer find her huge crayfish?

- (A) In Tasmania
- (B) In the ocean
- (C) In Kentucky
- (D) In a museum

2. What did her coworker say?

- (A) "That's the biggest ever!"
- (B) "No way, I've caught bigger."
- (C) "Crayfish can't be that big."
- (D) "Let's put it back."

3. What tools did the team use to measure the crayfish?

- (A) Calipers
- (B) Scales
- (C) Rulers made of string
- (D) Telescopes

4. How many extra-large crayfish did they find?

- (A) 86
- (B) 5
- (C) 20
- (D) 18

5. Which kind of crayfish was the biggest?

- (A) Crawzilla crawdad
- (B) Giant ocean crayfish
- (C) Tennessee bottlebrush crayfish
- (D) Kentucky river crayfish

6. What might stop the crayfish from growing bigger?

- (A) Not enough water
- (B) Cold weather
- (C) Their shells or muscles
- (D) People catching them

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: A 4: C 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):